I was aware a knighthood had been the subject of idle chatter around the time of my retirement from the England team. Theresa May, a cricket fan as well as prime minister, gave a rather flattering interview about her impressions of my career. In late October, Lord Tyrie submitted a written question, number HL10964, to the House of Lords ‘To ask Her Majesty’s Government what consideration they have given to recommending Alastair Cook for knighthood’.

Lord Young of Cookham, the Government’s spokesman, played an immaculate forward defensive: ‘The Government does not comment on individual honours nominations. Due to the confidential nature of the honours system, discretion regarding individual cases is considered important to safeguard [its] confidentiality and integrity …’

Recommendations are made by ten independent committees. I was unaware of the fact that confirmation of my honour was delayed because it had been posted to the wrong address. The letter from the Palace was redirected later, after Mike had been contacted. I would like to take the opportunity to apologize to my namesake, whoever he is, for the shock and ultimate disappointment he must have felt on receiving it in the first place.

The news broke, slightly prematurely, in *The Times* , where Michael Atherton wrote about me as a kindred spirit: ‘All openers know that the scoreboard reads 0–0 when they walk out to bat; the bowlers are at their freshest and most eager; the ball is shiny, hard and new and the seam at its most proud; and the fielders are full of optimism, and mouthy with it. Nowhere is easy to bat in international cricket but coming in occasionally at 200 for two allows the mind some respite and a reprieve. Openers never get that.’

Remember, though. That’s what we are talking about here – a cricketer. I’m not a life-saving hero, a cancer-curing scientist. I’ve been fortunate to play a game I love for so long, and I must say I do feel a little young to be a knight of the realm. It’s very strange to walk into a room and be announced as ‘Sir Alastair Cook’. I don’t think I’ll ever get used to that, as long as I live.

People don’t call me ‘Sir Alastair’ when I’m in the Red Lion or the Green Man, my closest village pubs. There are no airs and graces when I am worming the sheep. It will always be plain old Beefy and Cookie when we are together. As for my Essex teammates, they predictably came up with a